Brown University, Center for Quantitative Biology (Beijing), Institute of Chemical Process Fundamentals (Czech Republic), University of Oxford, University of Cape Town, Stanford University, Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, University of California Los Angeles, University of Pennsylvania and Vrije Universiteit Brussel which came out in the early days of March, conclusively studying how mask wearing could be used as an effective mitigation measure in the management and spread of COVID-19. The study presented simple cloth masks as a pragmatic solution for use by the public. It also synthesized literature across various relevant topics such as population impact, transmission characteristics, source control, wearer protection, and sociological and implementation considerations. In addition, it went on to clearly recommend that given the shortages of medical masks, the adoption of public cloth mask wearing was an effective form of source control.[20] In the meeting which followed after the prime minister had browsed through the literature, he directed the officials present that since mask wearing was more effective at reducing the spread of the virus when compliance was high, he would discuss it in his address to the nation scheduled soon. All departments of the GoI would push awareness of mask wearing and perhaps the states could even look at mandating it. He was much relieved that cloth masks were also quite effective making it possible for millions to make their own masks versus having to purchase them. For a country like ours, where a majority was still trapped in the cycle of poverty, a directive from the government to purchase a mask from the open market would just not work. Thus, just a few days after the PSA published guidance on how to use cloth face masks, the Department of Health recommended wearing home-made masks. Incidentally, it was around the same time that the US CDC also put out masking guidelines.[21] To offer a comparison to attest to the timeliness of this decision, there were over two lakh cases in the US as compared to less than a thousand in India at the time of publishing mask mandates.



On one hand, while the global media as well as subject matter experts were hailing the Indian leadership’s efforts to act quickly and decisively in an effort to rein in the spread of the contagion, several critics were attributing